The Korea Discount: Corporate Governance Deficits, Structural Reform, and the Limits of Voluntary Intervention

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Abstract

South Korean equities have traded at a persistent structural discount to developed-market and emerging-market peers for over three decades. This paper synthesizes 26 studies on the Korea Discount and presents original empirical evidence from a 20-year monthly panel of index-level price-to-book (P/B) ratios. The literature converges on three competing explanations—concentrated chaebol ownership and tunneling, weak minority shareholder protections, and stagnant growth fundamentals—but diverges on their relative importance. Cross-sectional regressions found formal governance scores insignificant once growth was controlled [양철원 et al., 2025], while natural experiments consistently identified ownership-based self-dealing as a direct value destroyer [Black et al., 2015]. We reconcile this divergence—formal indices measure board composition, not the ownership wedge that enables tunneling—using Japan's three governance reforms as a benchmark. A stacked event-study analysis shows that Japan's 2014 Stewardship Code and 2015 Corporate Governance Code—both voluntary—produced no sustained re-rating, while the 2023 TSE P/B reform generated a −6.48 P/B point cumulative abnormal spread over 24 months. Korea's 2024 Value-Up program, which remains voluntary, produced persistently negative CARs of -2.18, -1.80, and -2.12 P/B points against MSCI EM Asia at $\tau = 12$ for all three milestones. A geopolitical risk falsification rejects the North Korean threat explanation ($t = -0.84$, $p = 0.40$). The evidence supports hard legislative reform over soft governance codes.

1 Introduction

The "Korea Discount"—the persistent undervaluation of South Korean equities relative to global peers—is one of the most debated puzzles in international finance. Over 2004–2024, the KOSPI P/B ratio averaged 0.177× below TOPIX ($t = -3.23$) and 0.601× below MSCI EM ($t = -10.31$), with both gaps statistically significant under Newey-West HAC standard errors. The discount has persisted for at least three decades, widened after Japan's 2025 governance mandate, and resisted Korea's 2024 voluntary Value-Up program.

This paper makes two contributions. First, we synthesize 26 academic studies—including 14 published in Korean-language journals—organized around the competing explanations for the discount: governance and tunneling, growth fundamentals, and institutional stewardship. Second, we present original empirical evidence from a 20-year monthly panel covering KOSPI, TOPIX, S&P 500, and MSCI EM, using Japan's staged governance reforms as a policy benchmark. The central finding is that voluntary governance codes—whether Japan's 2014–2015 soft laws or Korea's 2024 Value-Up program—fail to produce sustained valuation improvement, while mandatory exchange-level enforcement with binding improvement plans and market-demotion consequences, as embodied in Japan's 2025 TSE P/B Mandate, does.

2 Defining and Measuring the Discount

The Korea Discount refers to the chronic undervaluation of Korean equities as measured by below-peer price-to-book (P/B) and price-to-earnings (P/E) ratios. The most comprehensive international evidence documented persistently lower P/B and P/E multiples for Korean firms across 48 countries from 1990 to 2023, even after controlling for firm size, profitability, growth, GDP per capita, financial market development, and geopolitical risk [김현석, 2026]. The finding held across all sub-periods (1990s, 2000s, 2010s onward), demonstrating that the discount was structural, not cyclical.

Whether the discount reflects risk or mispricing is contested. Korean firms with book-to-market (BTM) ratios above one consistently outperformed lower-BTM firms. Furthermore, high BTM was associated with a higher probability of positive extreme returns and a lower probability of negative extremes, indicating mispricing rather than risk compensation [정태진 et al., 2022]. A governance factor was the strongest cross-sectional predictor.

Figure 1 presents the 20-year P/B trajectory. Table 1 reports the headline statistics. The KOSPI–TOPIX spread averages $-0.177\times$ (NW SE = 0.055, $t = -3.23$, 95% CI: $[-0.284, -0.069]$); the KOSPI–MSCI EM spread averages $-0.601\times$ (NW SE = 0.058, $t = -10.31$, 95% CI: $[-0.716, -0.486]$). The sub-period decomposition shows structural deterioration: the KOSPI–TOPIX gap widens from 0.05 P/B points in 2004–2013 to 0.43 points in 2023–2024.

3 The Governance Channel: Chaebols, Tunneling, and Self-Dealing

3.1 Chaebol Ownership and Tunneling

The structural foundation of the Korea Discount lies in Korea's chaebol system—family-controlled conglomerates that dominate the economy. Mapping chaebol formation revealed that controlling families used "central firms" to acquire low-profitability entities through pyramidal structures. These central firms traded at a discount, reflecting shareholders' anticipation of value-destroying acquisitions [Almeida et al., 2011].

The economic scale of tunneling was substantial: when a chaebol-affiliated firm made

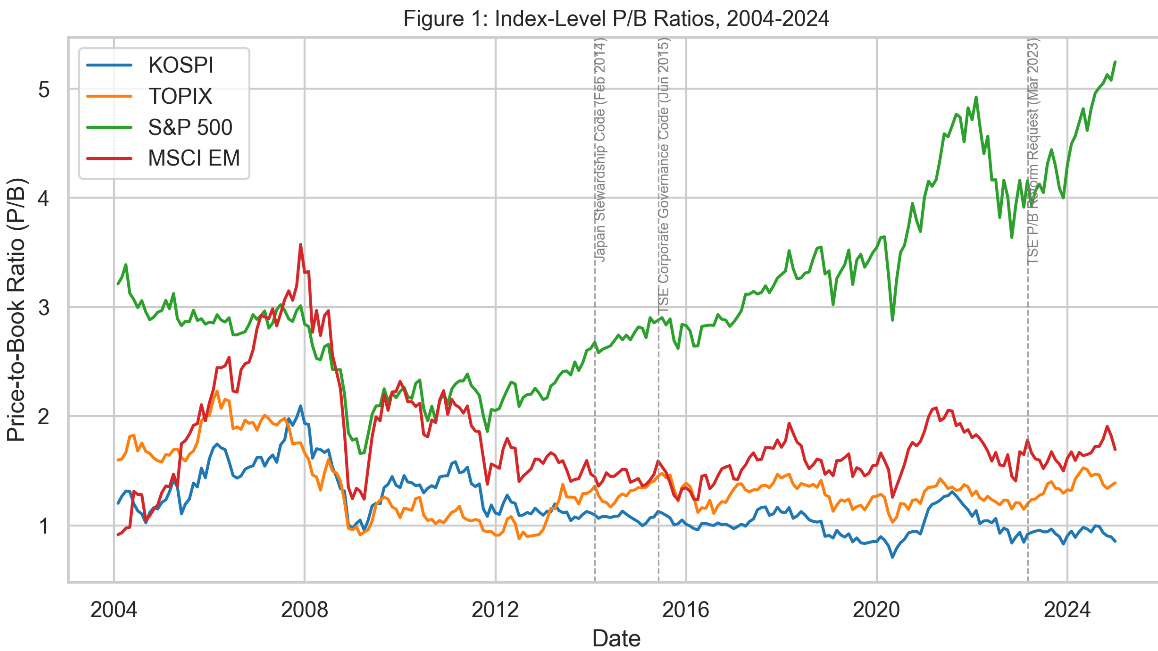


Figure 1: Monthly P/B ratios, January 2004–December 2024. Vertical lines mark Japan's governance reform milestones.

Table 1: Summary statistics of index-level P/B ratios by country and sub-period.

country	Period	mean	median	std	min	max
KOSPI	Full (2004–2024)	1.18	1.10	0.26	0.71	2.09
MSCI_EM	Full (2004–2024)	1.78	1.65	0.47	0.92	3.57
SP500	Full (2004–2024)	3.08	2.89	0.81	1.66	5.25
TOPIX	Full (2004–2024)	1.35	1.31	0.28	0.88	2.23
KOSPI	Pre-reform (2004–2013)	1.36	1.35	0.25	0.96	2.09
MSCI_EM	Pre-reform (2004–2013)	1.97	1.91	0.60	0.92	3.57
SP500	Pre-reform (2004–2013)	2.51	2.43	0.40	1.66	3.39
TOPIX	Pre-reform (2004–2013)	1.41	1.29	0.39	0.88	2.23
KOSPI	Reform era (2014–2022)	1.02	1.03	0.12	0.71	1.31
MSCI_EM	Reform era (2014–2022)	1.59	1.55	0.20	1.24	2.08
SP500	Reform era (2014–2022)	3.39	3.28	0.63	2.58	4.92
TOPIX	Reform era (2014–2022)	1.29	1.28	0.10	1.03	1.48
KOSPI	Post-TSE (2023–2024)	0.93	0.94	0.04	0.83	1.00
MSCI_EM	Post-TSE (2023–2024)	1.66	1.66	0.10	1.50	1.91
SP500	Post-TSE (2023–2024)	4.51	4.47	0.43	3.91	5.25
TOPIX	Post-TSE (2023–2024)	1.36	1.35	0.10	1.15	1.53

an acquisition, its stock price fell on average while the controlling shareholder benefited through value transfers to other group firms [Bae et al., 2002]. Business group-affiliated firms made systematically larger charitable donations. These donations were coordinated to tunnel resources from public affiliates (where families held lower cash flow rights) to private ones (where they held higher stakes) [Kim et al., 2019].

3.2 Natural Experiment Evidence

Exploiting Korea's 1999 reform that imposed stricter board requirements on large firms provides strong causal evidence. Event studies showed that large firms whose controllers had incentives to tunnel earned strong positive abnormal returns. Furthermore, panel regressions confirmed that better governance moderated the negative effect of related-party transactions on firm value and increased the sensitivity of firm profitability to industry profitability, consistent with reduced tunneling [Black et al., 2015].

Concentrated ownership also distorts the broader governance environment. Among chaebol-affiliated firms, only shareholder rights protection retained explanatory power for dividend payouts; board effectiveness, audit competency, and disclosure transparency lost independent influence once ownership structure was controlled [Njoku et al., 2026].

Another feature of chaebol conglomerates are their designated holding companies. Legally designated holding companies trade at significant P/B discounts relative to both operating companies and their fundamental values—a phenomenon unique to Korea and absent from Japan and the US [박진 et al., 2019]. Cross-shareholding voting restrictions could positively influence capital markets by exposing holding companies to boardroom coups, inducing revaluation [박진재, 2025]. However, this remains a defensive tactic rather than a fundamental governance improvement. Examining court rulings that weakened supermajority anti-takeover provisions showed that firms with such provisions outperformed, supporting their value-enhancing role when not abused for entrenchment [Kim and Han, 2022].

4 The Growth vs. Governance Debate

The tunneling and self-dealing evidence in Section 3 makes a strong case for governance as the primary driver of the discount, but there is a strand of cross-sectional literature does appear to contradict this.

Cross-sectional tests found that formal corporate governance scores had *no* significant relationship with PBR. Stagnant growth variables instead dominated: low R&D intensity, high tangible-asset intensity, and firm maturity all exhibited strong positive correlations with low PBR, while higher shareholder payouts were paradoxically associated with *lower* PBR [양철원 et al., 2025]. Large manufacturers corroborated this pattern—dividend expansion had weak or negative effects on PBR, and R&D investment was the more significant predictor [이정환, 2025]. Across 58 markets from 2001 to 2018, Korea's formal shareholder rights scores were not distinctively low. What set Korea apart was low *value relevance*: profitability and growth were incorporated into prices to a far lesser degree than in comparable markets (51st of 58 countries), pointing to a short-term investment culture that prevented long-term expectations from being capitalized [김현석 et al., 2025].

These findings are striking, but they test the wrong construct. The expropriation channel operates through the wedge between controlling families' voting rights and their economic stake—not through the board-composition and disclosure indices that governance scores measure. A chaebol can score adequately on formal metrics while simultaneously operating pyramidal structures that divert profits from public affiliates to private ones [Almeida et al., 2011]. Reducing family ownership concentration directly shrinks this wedge: as controlling shareholders capture a smaller share of private benefits, more earnings flow to minority shareholders, and P/B rises. This is a governance mechanism—a reduction in expropriation risk—that index scores are structurally ill-equipped to detect. The two channels also reinforce one another: concentrated control depresses R&D investment (registering as a growth deficit) because controlling shareholders prefer low-risk, tunnelable cash flows over long-horizon innovation spending; low value relevance then weakens the market penalty for value-destroying acquisitions, further entrenching the cycle. Hard reform that raises the cost of non-compliance disrupts this feedback at its root—the mechanism Section 6 tests empirically.

5 Institutional Stewardship: Promises and Limits

5.1 NPS Activism

Korea's first policy response leveraged the National Pension Service (NPS) as an activist institutional shareholder. However, markets did not react to NPS "Vote No" announcements, a result inconsistent with developed-market activism, though firms that subsequently improved internal governance showed higher valuations [Kim et al., 2014]. NPS shareholding improved ESG performance and financial outcomes, with ESG serving as the primary transmission channel [Kim et al., 2022]. Furthermore, NPS ESG engagement disclosures were associated with significant firm value gains. These effects were strongest for firms with the weakest internal governance, indicating that institutional activism substituted for, rather than complemented, internal governance [Lee and Nam, 2026].

5.2 Stewardship Code and Foreign Investors

Korea's 2016 Stewardship Code also asked institutional investors to adopt principles of responsible engagement—voting actively on shareholder resolutions, disclosing conflicts of interest, and monitoring investee companies—with the goal of improving corporate governance through investor pressure rather than legislative mandate. While a positive correlation was found between Stewardship Code adoption and earnings quality, multivariate regressions failed to establish statistical significance [박성환 et al., 2021]. The broader challenge was that Korea's formal governance scores were not distinctively lower than those of its peers; the problem lay in enforcement credibility rather than established norms [김현석 et al., 2025].

Foreign investors facilitated the incorporation of firm-specific information into stock prices more effectively than domestic institutions [Kim and Yi, 2015]. Foreign ownership also reduced growth disparities through asymmetric discipline—correcting over-investment in over-growing firms and encouraging profitable management in under-growing ones. This implied that governance reforms that improved market accessibility could significantly amplify foreign investor discipline [주병철, 2026].

6 Reform Benchmarks: Japan's Arc and Korea's Voluntary Response

6.1 Japan's Staged Governance Trajectory

Japan faced a structurally similar valuation discount through the 2000s and 2010s, attributed to cross-shareholding (*keiretsu*), weak board independence, and low dividend payouts. The government responded with three reforms escalating enforcement: (i) the Stewardship Code (February 2014), requiring institutional governance engagement; (ii) the Corporate Governance Code (June 2015), mandating board composition and disclosure standards; (iii) the TSE P/B Reform Request (March 2023), asking Prime Market firms below 1.0× book value to voluntarily disclose their awareness of capital efficiency shortfalls and outline improvement plans—without binding targets or enforcement consequences; and (iv) the TSE P/B Mandate (January 2025), requiring Prime Market firms below 1.0× book value to submit binding, multi-year capital efficiency improvement plans with specific quantitative targets under threat of automatic demotion to the Standard Market.

6.2 Korea's Value-Up Program

Korea's 2024 Corporate Value-Up Program mirrors Japan's reform arc in aspiration but not in enforcement. Most listed companies ignored the voluntary guidelines, and the KOSPI closed weaker in 2024—the opposite outcome from Japan's experience following its 2025 TSE mandate. Evaluations of the program found low participation and weak market responses

[이진효, 2025]. Conversely, direct market evidence showed that *legislative* reform shifted expectations: the 2025 Commercial Act amendment (which expanded directors' fiduciary duties to shareholders) produced significantly positive abnormal returns for high-book-to-market firms. There was no significant reaction among firms with high controlling-shareholder ownership, indicating that markets expected the reform to be most effective where expropriation risk was highest [강나라 and 김희주, 2026].

6.3 Empirical Evidence: Japan Reform Benchmark

We estimate stacked event studies around Japan's three reform dates, using both a KOSPI–TOPIX spread (secondary) and an MSCI EM Asia–TOPIX spread (primary, insulating results from Japan-specific dynamics). Figure 2 presents the results.

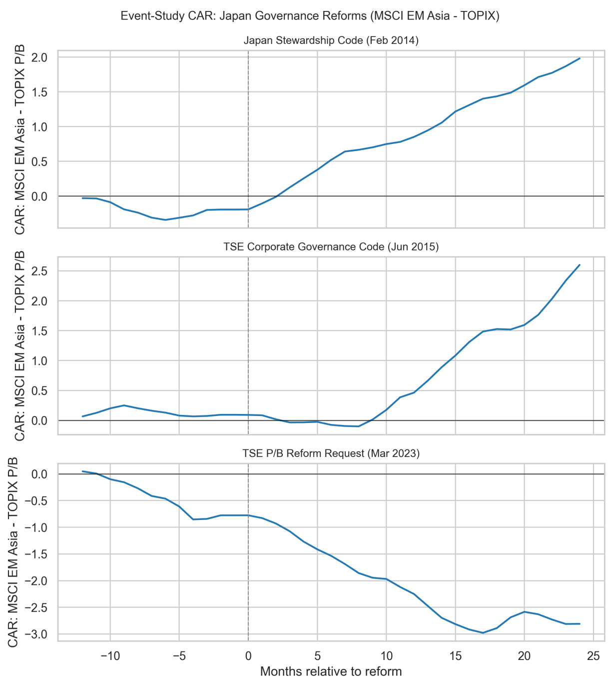
2014 Stewardship Code. The MSCI EM Asia–TOPIX CAR reaches +1.60 at $\tau = 20$—no sustained TOPIX re-rating. Korea did not underperform relative to trend.

2015 Corporate Governance Code. Qualitatively identical: KOSPI–TOPIX CAR +7.83 at $\tau = 24$; Asia CAR +1.60 at $\tau = 20$. Neither soft-law event produced an enforceable governance shock.

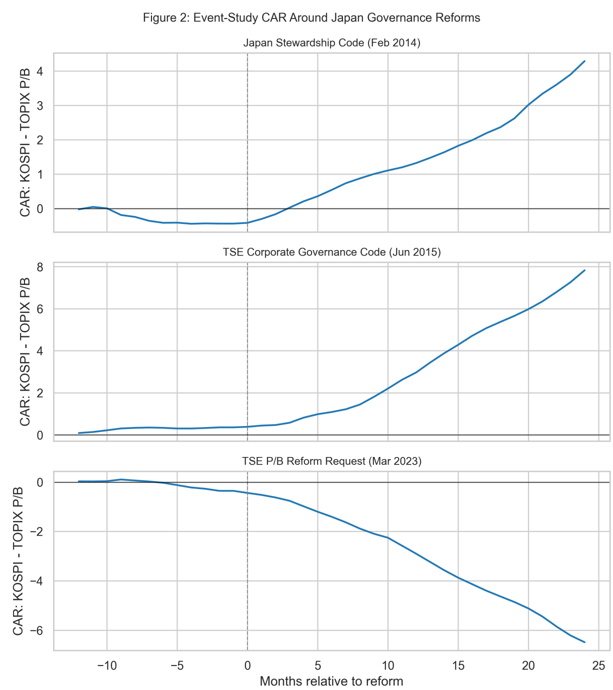
2023 TSE P/B Reform. Sharply different. The KOSPI–TOPIX CAR monotonically declines to -6.48 at $\tau = 24$; the MSCI EM Asia–TOPIX CAR reaches -2.58 at $\tau = 20$. Japan's hard mandate caused the largest spread movement in the sample, and the MSCI EM Asia comparison confirms this is not Japan-specific appreciation.

6.4 Empirical Evidence: Korea's Value-Up Program

Figure 3 presents the Korea Value-Up event study. All three milestones produce persistently negative CARs against MSCI EM Asia. For the program launch (February 2024): KOSPI–MSCI EM Asia CAR -2.18 at $\tau = 12$ and -4.14 at $\tau = 20$. For the guidelines unveiling (May 2024): -1.80 at $\tau = 12$. For the implementation push (August 2024): -2.12 at $\tau = 12$. The MSCI EM Asia specification rules out Japan-specific dynamics. Korea's voluntary program



(a) MSCI EM Asia–TOPIX



(b) KOSPI–TOPIX

Figure 2: Japan governance reform event studies. The 2023 reform produces a −6.48 P/B point KOSPI–TOPIX CAR, while earlier soft codes produce no sustained effect.

produced no improvement in relative valuation.

6.5 Panel OLS and Geopolitical Risk

Panel OLS with two-way fixed effects and wild-bootstrap inference (999 Rademacher draws, clustered by country) produces imprecise reform-by-Japan interactions: Stewardship Code $\times$ Japan $= +0.09$ [$p_{\text{wild}} = 0.625$]; CGC $\times$ Japan $= -0.32$ [$p_{\text{wild}} = 0.375$]; TSE P/B (2025) $\times$ Japan $= -0.23$ [$p_{\text{wild}} = 0.500$]. With $N = 4$ clusters, these are descriptive rather than inferential.

The geopolitical risk falsification estimates KOSPI P/B on Korea GPR escalation (GPRC_-KOR above its 75th percentile), controlling for TOPIX P/B and year fixed effects over 252 monthly observations. The GPR coefficient is −0.016 ($t = -0.84$, $p = 0.41$)—statistically insignificant and economically negligible (less than one-tenth of the mean KOSPI–TOPIX spread). The test is biased toward finding an effect and still finds none.

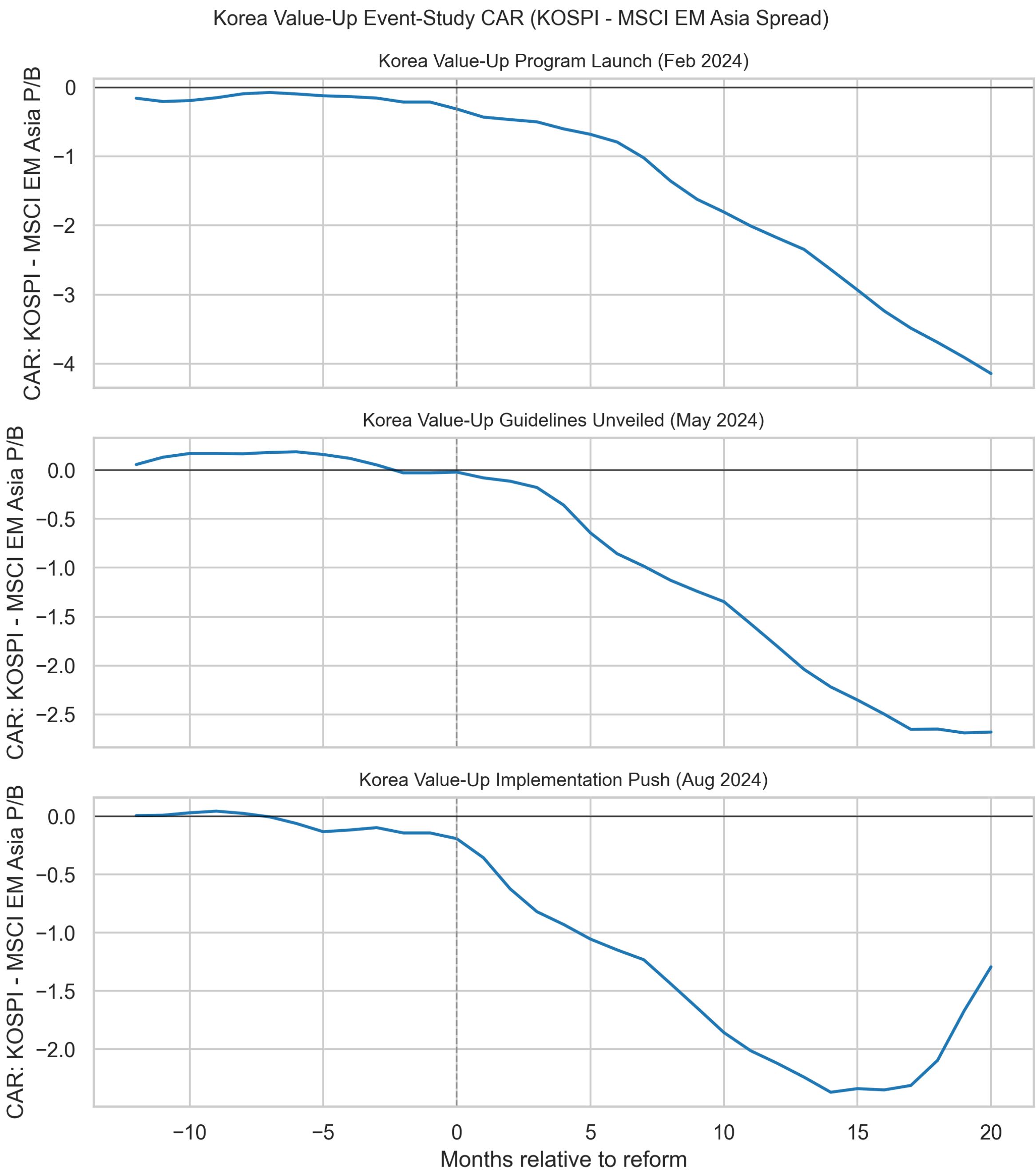


Figure 3: Korea Value-Up event study (KOSPI–MSCI EM Asia). All three milestones produce persistently negative CARs.

7 Geopolitical Risk and Other Explanations

North Korean geopolitical risk is a commonly cited but empirically weak alternative explanation for the Korea Discount. The intuition is straightforward: proximity to an unpredictable nuclear-armed state should depress valuations by raising the equity risk premium. Yet cross-country studies that control for geopolitical risk explicitly find the discount survives intact, consistent with markets treating North Korean threats as a chronic, well-priced background condition rather than a source of incremental uncertainty. Our GPR falsification in Section 6 formalizes this test: the Korea GPR escalation coefficient is -0.016 ($t = -0.84$, $p = 0.41$)—statistically indistinguishable from zero and economically negligible relative to the mean KOSPI–TOPIX spread. Figure 4 presents the KOSPI P/B series alongside GPR escalation episodes; no systematic co-movement is apparent even around the most acute crises. Korea's economic policy uncertainty index—not military threat—explained cross-country discount differentials [김현석 et al., 2025].

Two further alternative explanations receive partial support. Initial audit fees were significantly lower during high-sentiment periods in Korea's low-litigation environment, suggesting that optimistic bias reduced monitoring quality and thereby amplified the governance channel [Yun and Kim, 2022]—a complementary rather than competing account. Financial media have attributed the discount primarily to poor corporate governance at chaebols, describing "tunneling" and "propping" as mechanisms through which insiders benefited at minority shareholders' expense [The Economist, 2012], consistent with the causal evidence reviewed in Section 3.

8 Synthesis and Policy Implications

The literature and empirical evidence converge on: mitigating the Korea Discount requires hard legislative reform, not continued reliance on soft-law guidelines. Six findings support this:

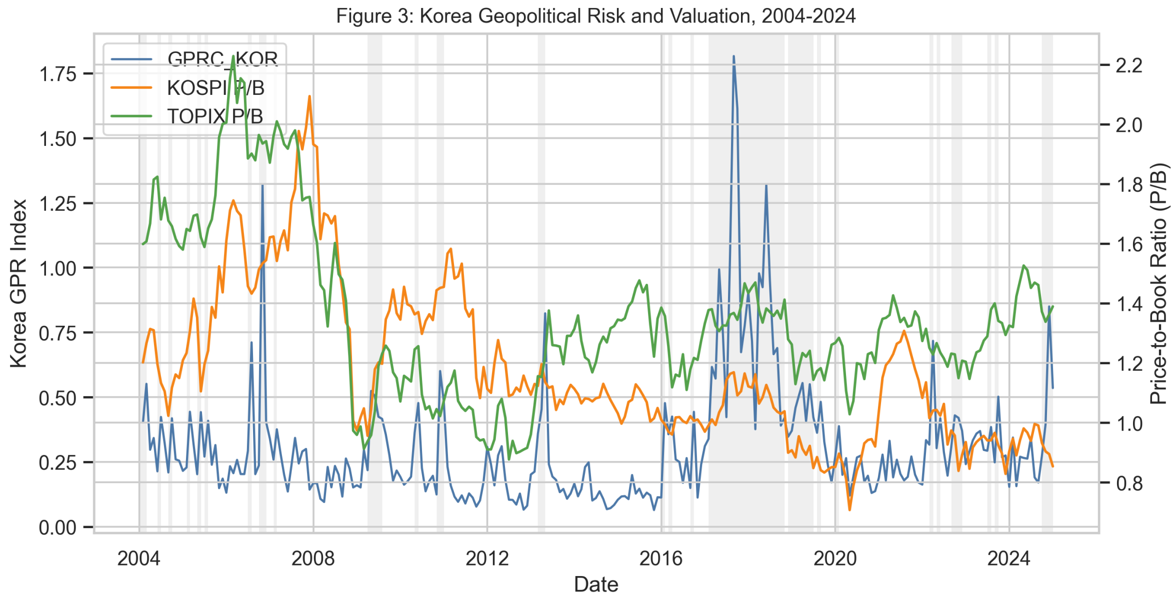


Figure 4: KOSPI P/B and North Korea geopolitical risk escalation episodes. Shaded regions mark periods when the Korea GPR index (GPRC_KOR) exceeded its 75th percentile. No systematic co-movement is apparent; the regression coefficient is -0.016 ($t = -0.84$, $p = 0.41$).

First, cross-sectional evidence contesting the governance hypothesis [양철원 et al., 2025, 이정환, 2025] tests formal index scores, not the ownership wedge that enables tunneling; the null finding on scores is therefore consistent with, not contradictory to, the causal evidence that reducing expropriation risk raises P/B [Black et al., 2015].

Second, the asymmetry between Japan's soft and hard governance codes is the central empirical finding. The 2014 and 2015 voluntary codes produced no sustained TOPIX re-rating; the 2025 mandatory P/B mandate produced a -6.48 P/B point KOSPI–TOPIX CAR. Korea's 2024 voluntary Value-Up program produced negative CARs against MSCI EM Asia at all three milestones.

Third, institutional stewardship through the NPS has produced conditional improvements [Kim et al., 2022, Lee and Nam, 2026] but lacks enforcement credibility absent structural reform [Kim et al., 2014, 박성환 et al., 2021].

Fourth, the geopolitical risk channel is empirically unsupported ($t = -0.84$, $p = 0.40$).

Fifth, foreign investor discipline [Kim and Yi, 2015, 주병철, 2026] offers a complementary channel, but only when market accessibility improvements accompany governance reform.

Sixth, the 2025 Commercial Act amendment [강나라 and 김희주, 2026] produced significant positive abnormal returns for high-discount firms, validating the hard-law mechanism; yet fiduciary duty expansion falls short of Japan's 2025 TSE mandate, which pairs binding improvement plans with automatic market demotion for persistent non-compliance.

The practical implication is that Korea has closed the legislative gap with its 2025 Commercial Act but has not yet closed the exchange-level enforcement gap. Japan's 2025 TSE P/B Mandate—requiring Prime Market firms to submit binding, multi-year improvement plans with quantitative targets under threat of automatic demotion—represents a harder constraint than fiduciary duty expansion alone, precisely because it operates at the point of listing, not through litigation. The asymmetry between Japan's soft codes (no sustained re-rating) and its 2025 hard mandate (-6.48 P/B point KOSPI–TOPIX CAR) identifies this exchange-level mechanism as the marginal intervention. Whether Korea's 2025 Commercial Act produces a comparable re-rating without an accompanying TSE-style exchange mandate is an empirical question that the next several years of data will answer.

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